

Introduction to Sociology (Socialization)

(Ref: Richard T. Schaefer, Sociology, 10th Ed., McGraw Hills Online Resources, <http://www.mhhe.com/schaefer10>)

Socialization

“People learn attitudes, values, and behaviors appropriate for members of a particular culture”

- A life long process
- Shapes our self-images
- Occurs through human interactions
- Interaction may be direct or indirect
 - Immediate family members, best friends, teachers
 - People on the street, on television, on the internet, in films and magazines

Socialization

- Micro sociological perspective:
 - Helps to discover how to behave properly
 - What to expect from others if we follow (or challenge) society's norms and values
- Macro sociological perspective:
 - Helps in transmission of a culture from one generation to the next for long term continuance of a society

Role of socialization

Interplay of heredity / environment

- Social environment: The impact of isolation (the case of Isabelle)
- The influence of heredity

Attitudes, values, chosen mates, drinking habits influenced by social environment

Temperaments, voice patterns, nervous habits influenced by heredity

Role of socialization

Ex: What events in your life have had a strong influence on who you are?

The self and socialization

Who we are?

- The self emerges as we interact with others
- “Self” is a distinct identity that sets us apart from others
- Not a static phenomenon

Sociological approaches to the self

Looking-glass self [Cooley, early 1900s] – interactionist perspective

- Self is the product of our social interaction
- Process of developing a self-identity or self-concept
 1. We imagine how we present ourselves to others
 2. We imagine how others evaluate us
 3. We develop some sort of feeling about ourselves

=> We can develop self-identities based upon incorrect perceptions of how others see us

The self and socialization

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Sociological approaches to the self

Stages of the self [Mead, 1934] – interactionist perspective

- Process of developing a self-identity
 1. The preparatory stage
 2. The play stage
 3. The game stage

Sociological approaches to the self

1. The preparatory stage (infancy/pre-school): children merely imitate the people around them, especially family members with whom they interact
 - Begin to understand symbols, gestures, ...
 2. The play stage: children begin to pretend to be other people; *role playing*
 3. The game stage (8/9 years old): children begin to consider several tasks and relationships simultaneously; generalized other; significant others
 - Knows their position and position of others (for role playing)
- generalized other: *attitudes, view points and expectations of a society as a whole that a child takes into account in his / her behaviors*

Sociological approaches to the self

Presentation of the self [Goffman, 1959] – interactionist perspective

- How do we display to the others who we are?
 1. Impression management: Individual slants his / her presentation of the self in order to create distinctive appearances and satisfy particular audiences
 - grading system (ace-ace /, ace-bomber / bomber-bomber encounters)
 2. Face-work: How often do you initiate some kind of face-saving behavior when you feel embarrassed or rejected? – needed to continue social interaction

Ex:

- How do you react with those who have received higher or lower grades than you? Do you engage in impression management? How would you like others to react to your grades?
- What social norms govern students' impression management strategies?
- Identify a couple of embarrassing situations in an on-line social environment that you have been using. How did the embarrassed users react to those situations?

Psychological approaches to the self

Freud, S. (1856-1939) stressed the role of inborn drives in channeling human behavior

- Self is a social product
- Aspects of one's personality are influenced by other people especially one's parents
- Self has components that work in opposition to each other
 - Natural impulsive instincts are in constant conflict with societal constraints
 - Part of us seeks limitless pleasure while another part favors rational behavior

Psychological approaches to the self

[Piaget, 1954] Cognitive theory of development: Stages in the development of children's thought processes

1. Sensorimotor stage
2. Preoperational stage
3. Concrete operational stage
4. Formal operational stage

Psychological approaches to the self

1. Sensorimotor stage: young children use their senses to make discoveries, e.g; through touching they discover that hands are actually part of themselves
2. Preoperational stage: children begin to use words and symbols to distinguish objects and ideas, e.g; table, clay, good work
3. Concrete operational stage: children engage in more logical thinking, e.g; they learn that a formless lump of clay is shaped into a snake, it still the same clay
4. Formal operational stage: adolescents become capable of sophisticated abstract thought , and can deal with ideas and values in a logical manner, e.g; mathematical calculations, reasoning, and systematic thinking

The life course

- Rites of passage
- Anticipatory socialization
- Resocialization

The life course

- Rites of passage: A means of dramatizing and validating changes in a person's status
 - Milestones in the transition to adulthood (based on 2002 general social survey, T. Smith 2003)
 - Financial independence from parents / guardians
 - Separate residence from parents
 - Full-time employment
 - Completion of formal schooling
 - Capability of supporting a family
 - Marriage
 - Parenthood
 - More difficult socialization challenges later in life

The life course

- Rites of passage: A means of dramatizing and validating changes in a person's status
 - Milestones in the transition to adulthood (based on 2002 general social survey, T. Smith 2003)
 - More difficult socialization challenges later in life
 - Assessing one's accomplishments
 - Coping with declining physical / cognitive abilities
 - Experiencing retirement
 - Facing inevitability of passing away

- Ex: What was the last rite of passage you participated in? Was it formal or informal?

The life course

- Anticipatory socialization: Processes of socialization in which a person rehearses for future positions, occupations and social relationships, e.g; searching for appropriate college / Univ.

The life course

- Resocialization: Process of discarding former behavior patterns and accepting new ones as part of a transition in one's life
 - Total institution
 - Degradation ceremony

Agents of socialization

- Family
- Cultural influences
- Race and gender
- School
- Peer group
- Mass media and technology
- Workplace
- Religion and the state

- Case study: blogs v/s twitter